

## **Chapter 3**

### **The False Prophet**

Having examined the person and stratagems of the Antichrist concerning the mark of the beast, it is appropriate to touch upon the last of the satanic triad, the False Prophet. Just like his peers, the False Prophet is known by multiple titles, namely, the earth-beast (Rev. 13:11), and he also plays a crucial role concerning the mark that merits its own exposition. Akin to the first beast, the Antichrist, the evidence concerning the identity of the False Prophet does not lead to a specific political or religious figure in today's times. However, biblical evidence does astoundingly present a picture of the person of the False Prophet to warn us of the reality of that person to come.

With Caesar Nero being the (picture of the) person, conduct, and character of the Antichrist, to know the person of the False Prophet, let us again piece together the evidence and context contained in the scriptures. The False Prophet as the land-beast is detailed explicitly in the Bible to have come “up out of the earth” in Revelation 13:11. The Greek word for “the earth” here is “τῆς γῆς”, or in translated in Hebrew as “ha aretz” (הָאֶרֶץ), meaning “the land”, a reference to the land of Israel, the good land. Though the literal meaning of the Hebrew term “ha aretz” does not objectively refer to any specific part of the earth, in the context of the Bible, especially throughout the Old Testament, the use of the term “the land” in hundreds of occurrences refers to the land of Israel, rather than a generic part of the earth (Gen. 48:4; Exo. 20:12; Lev 18:27; Num. 15:2; Deut. 1:8; Josh. 1:2; Judg. 18:2; 1 Sam. 13:3; 2 Sam. 5:6; Psalm 37; Isa. 5:8; Jer. 2:7; Ezek. 6:14; Dan. 11:16). Hence, we see the first beast came up out of the Abyss from out of the sea (Rev. 13:1), that is the Mediterranean Sea in the biblical context signifying the gentile nations, and this beast came up out from the land, signifying the land of Israel, revealing that the False Prophet will either be Jewish, or a person of Jewish background.

The appearance of the False Prophet reveals further details of his background and identity. His appearance like a lamb seems to be an open imitation of Christ (Rev. 13:11; cf. John 1:29; Rev. 5:6), as befitting to his prowess in deception (Rev. 13:14, 19:20). The first beast, who is the Antichrist as a gentile ruler's appearance was by no means similar to that of the true Christ's, nor was it pretending to be. But concerning the False Prophet's appearance as a lamb as an imitation of Christ, who is Jewish by genealogy (Matt. 1:1), suggests that the False Prophet may most likely have a Jewish background and originate from the land of Israel.

### **Judas Iscariot**

According to the interpretations of Witness Lee and many other biblical teachers and scholars, the person of the False Prophet is most likely to be Judas Iscariot. Without speculation, the author will provide further evidence from the Bible that further confirms this interpretation. Lee noted in the book ‘The Prophecy of the Four Sevens’ that Judas Iscariot uniquely went to “his own place” after he died (Acts 1:25), unlike other instances in the Bible where a person goes to

“his people” after their physical death (1), like for Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob (Gen. 25:8, 35:29, 49:33), Aaron (Num. 20:24), David (1 Kings 2:10), Solomon (1 Kings 11:43) and many of the kings of Judah (1 Kings 22:50, 2 Kings 20:21). Hence, those who were taken to a place which are not known by men are typically reserved for a reappearance later in time, such as Moses and Elijah, who will probably reappear as the two witnesses during the time of the great tribulation (Rev. 11:3), and this is even true for Christ Himself, has gone to a place where we cannot go (John 8:22, 13:33), and will soon return.

Moreover, the smoking gun is found in John’s gospel, the same author as the book of Revelation, as an apostle and coworker with Judas for three and a half years, and is further confirmed in Paul’s writings. The apostle John, the author of Revelation, wrote in his gospel that Judas Iscariot is a devil and called by the Lord as such (John 6:70), and specifically named Judas Iscariot to be the devil which Jesus referred to (6:71). The Greek word for the “devil” written in John 6:70 is “διάβολός”, transliterated in English “diabolos”, and is the same word used to refer to Satan when he came to tempt Jesus in wilderness in chapter 4 of Matthew and Luke, and so throughout the gospels. While Jesus walked on earth during His ministry, He has never called or given anyone a title as severe as “the devil”, with Him referring to the Pharisees and scribes as “offspring of vipers” (Matt. 12:34, 23:33), and to king Herod who wants to kill Him “that fox” (Luke 13:31). The term “the devil” is also used ontologically when Jesus referred called out Judas be to a devil, meaning the term “devil” is implied to be equivalent to Judas. In contrast, when Jesus told Satan to get behind Him in Matthew chapter 18, it was only a functional rebuke, not an equivocal one. The reason why Jesus considers Judas Iscariot to be equivalent to the devil can be found in Luke and John’s writings, where both authors wrote that Satan entered into Judas Iscariot (Luke 22:3; John 13:37). Astoundingly, the two authors bear witness to the only occurrence in the Bible where it is explicitly said that Satan himself entered into a person.

In the intimate prayer between the Lord Jesus and the Father in John chapter 17, what the Lord revealed concerning the title and future of Judas Iscariot may be most conclusive to the interpretation that Judas Iscariot is the False Prophet. “When I was with them, I kept them in Your name, which You have given to Me, and I guarded them; and not one of them perished, except the son of perdition, that the Scripture might be fulfilled” (John 17:12). In His prayer to the Father, He was burdened to pray for His apostles and disciples to be preserved, and this was fulfilled when Jesus was with them from the beginning of His ministry up to the day of His crucifixion, only one perished, that is Judas Iscariot when he hanged himself after seeing Jesus was condemned (Matt. 27:3-5). Thus, the reference to Judas Iscariot as “the son of perdition” by Christ undoubtably confirms his eternal fate, as the fulfilment of the scripture is for the False Prophet to be cast into the lake of fire (Rev. 19:20) alongside the Antichrist.

What is most fascinating about the term “the son of perdition” is that it is mentioned only twice in the Bible, the second time in the apostle Paul’s epistle to the Thessalonians on the coming Antichrist. “Let no one deceive you in any way, because it will not come unless the

apostasy comes first and the man of lawlessness is revealed, the son of perdition” (2 Thes. 2:3). Here the term “the son of perdition” was given to the Antichrist as the “man of lawlessness”, the one who intends to change the law (Dan. 7:25) and to exult himself above all (2 Thes. 2:4, Dan. 11:36). We see that the same term “the son of perdition” used by Christ to address Judas Iscariot was the same term used by Paul to address the Antichrist, implying both are of equal in their status and fate. Making both characters, the Antichrist and the False Prophet the two sons of perdition, which will be fulfilled in Revelation 19:20, when both beasts are seized, and both are cast alive into the lake of fire burning with brimstone.

## **The Treasurer of the Apostles**

Now that we have established the person of the False Prophet to most likely be Judas Iscariot, we can similarly gain a greater understanding of his role with the mark of the beast, as we have with the Antichrist, through looking into their conduct and deeds while they were once alive on the earth. Unsurprisingly, Judas Iscariot was the treasurer of the apostles, meaning he possessed and controlled the purse (John 12:6, 13:29), which the Greek word “γλωσσόκομον” is also translated as “moneybox or moneybag, the modern-day equivalent of the wallet. And the transactions of buying or selling by the apostles and the disciples for the necessities of life were mostly under the control of Judas Iscariot (John 13:29). As the treasurer, Judas was effectively in control of the finances and money of the apostles, a matter which may have displeased the apostle John, when he called out Judas Iscariot for stealing and misusing the funds of the group in writing his gospel (John 12:6).

Therefore, we see that in the gospel of John, Judas Iscariot was in control of the money of the followers of Christ, that is, the apostles and disciples, who will most likely be the coming False Prophet in Revelation, who will be in control of the money of everyone alive on the earth when he comes. The “he” in Revelation 13:16, “and he causes all, the small and the great, and the rich and the poor, and the freemen and the slaves, to be given a mark”, refers to the False Prophet in the context of previous verses from verse 11 onwards. And that no one without the mark would be able to carry out transactions with money, buying or selling, implying the Antichrist and the False Prophet having total control and authority (Rev. 13:12) over the financial and monetary systems of the world at the time of their coming as to permit who can use money to live, and who cannot. To a greater extend, Judas Iscariot, who once was in control of the moneybag of the followers of Christ will be in control the “moneybags” of everyone on earth (Rev. 13:16) when the False Prophet come; just like Caesar Nero, who once persecuted the followers of Christ throughout the Roman Empire will exercise authority over the whole earth to persecute the saints when the Antichrist comes (Rev. 13:7; Dan. 7:21).

## **Monetary Prowess of the Satanic Triad**

The thorough understanding of the persons of the Antichrist and the False Prophet enables us to see their backgrounds, historical context, character, conducts, and deeds to in aiding us to be wise to their schemes and intentions, revealing why a central piece to their operations in

the end times, the mark of the beast, carries such economic, monetary, and commercial significance and consequences (Rev. 13:17).

It is no coincidence that the three significant figures behind the mark of the beast were experienced and knowledgeable in money and monetary systems of control. With Satan's rulership over this world (John 14:30; Eph. 6:12), being a master of commerce (Ezek. 28:4, 16) and a businessman (Ezek. 28:5), Caesar Nero's authoritative currency controls and influence over the economic activities within the Roman Empire, and Judas Iscariot's love of money and former position as the treasurer once in control of the moneybag of Christ's followers. All three characters of the triad possess unique monetary prowess and expertise, setting the foundation for the reality of the economic and monetary consequences of the mark of the beast.